

Figure 2.5 The Queen Bee (1935) – the first operational radio-controlled drone.⏎

2.6.2.4 Radioplane OQ-2 (1939)

The Radioplane OQ-2 (1939), developed by Reginald Denny Industries in the United States, represents a major technological and industrial milestone in the evolution of unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs). Created as a radio-controlled target drone for the US Army Air Corps, it was specifically designed to provide realistic moving targets for anti-aircraft gunnery training. The OQ-2 became the first mass-produced UAV in history, symbolizing the beginning of the industrialization and operational deployment of drones during World War II.

Reginald Denny, a British actor, aviator, and model aircraft enthusiast, played a pioneering role in transforming radio-controlled flight from a hobbyist pursuit into a military technology. His company, Reginald Denny Industries, collaborated with the US Army and engineer Walter Righter, who designed a reliable two-cylinder, two-stroke piston engine to power the drone. The result was a compact, lightweight, and cost-effective aircraft that could be launched by catapult and recovered via parachute, enabling repeated use (Jeler, 2020).